

The River That Couldn't Smile

A Story About Plastic Pollution



Every summer, Maya and her cousin Leo visited Grandpa Arun's little riverside village. The river used to sparkle like glass. Children splashed in the cool water. Fish darted between smooth stones. Kingfishers perched on branches, waiting for breakfast. But this summer, something had changed. Plastic bottles floated along the river. Colorful wrappers clung to the reeds. A turtle struggled to swim through a tangled plastic bag. "The river looks... sad," Maya whispered. Grandpa Arun nodded. "It needs our help."

Even
our rivers
can feel
sad.



The Turtle's Secret



The next morning, the cousins carefully picked up litter along the riverbank.

As Leo reached for an old bottle, something moved. A small turtle slowly crawled from beneath the grass.

It wasn't hurt anymore, but pieces of plastic surrounded its nest.

Grandpa Arun gently explained, "Animals don't know the difference between food and plastic."

"Some eat it."

"Others become trapped in it."

Maya looked at the turtle.

"It isn't just ugly."

"It's dangerous."

Did You Know?

Turtles often mistake plastic bags for jellyfish—one of their favorite foods. It can make them very sick or even kill them.





The children followed the river upstream.

Near a bridge, the wind pushed plastic cups, snack wrappers, and bags into the water.

Rain washed even more litter from the streets.

“The river didn’t make this mess,”
Leo said.

“We did.”

Grandpa Arun smiled sadly.

“The good news is...”

“If people caused the problem...”

“...people can solve it too.”

Did You Know?

Most plastic starts on land. It can be blown by the wind or washed by rain into drains, rivers, and finally the ocean.



The River Rescue Team



The cousins invited their friends to help. Soon everyone carried gloves, buckets, and recycling bags. Some sorted plastic bottles. Others picked up fishing line. One group planted flowers along the riverbank. Another painted colorful signs: "Take Your Trash Home." As the day went on, the river slowly began to sparkle again. Even birds returned to the trees.



Did You Know?



Use a reusable water bottle.



Bring reusable bags.



Recycle what you can.



Never litter.



Join a community cleanup.

One Small Bottle



Before leaving, Maya picked up one last plastic bottle.
“It doesn’t seem like much,” she said.
Grandpa Arun smiled.
“Neither does one raindrop.”
“But millions of raindrops fill a river.”
Leo grinned.
“And millions of people making one good choice...
...can change the world.”
The river shimmered in the afternoon sun.
This time...
it almost looked like
it was smiling.

Did You Know?

It takes hundreds of years for most plastic to break down. But we have the power to keep our rivers and oceans clean—for today, tomorrow, and forever!





PLASTIC POLLUTION

Plastic is useful because it is strong and lasts a long time.

But when plastic is thrown into nature, it doesn't disappear.

Many plastic items can take hundreds of years to break down.

Instead, they slowly break into tiny pieces called microplastics.

These tiny pieces can enter rivers, oceans, animals, and even our food.



HOW PLASTIC HURTS WILDLIFE



Turtles may mistake plastic bags for jellyfish.



Birds sometimes feed plastic pieces to their chicks.



Fish can swallow tiny bits of plastic.



Animals may become trapped in fishing nets or plastic rings.

HOW WE CAN HELP



Recycle whenever possible.



Use reusable bottles and shopping bags.



Never litter.



Join a community cleanup.



Pick up litter even if it isn't yours.



REMEMBER

Every piece of plastic you keep out of nature helps protect animals, rivers, and oceans.

